



DVT VS. CELLULITIS – NCLEX

OVERVIEW

Feature	Deep Vein Thrombosis (DVT)	Cellulitis
Definition	Formation of a blood clot in a deep vein, usually in the lower extremities	Acute bacterial skin and subcutaneous tissue infection
Etiology (Causes)	- Venous stasis (immobility, post-op) - Hypercoagulability - Endothelial injury (Virchow's triad)	- Streptococcus or Staphylococcus - Skin break or wound
Risk Factors	- Recent surgery or trauma - Prolonged immobility - Obesity - Smoking - Oral contraceptives - Cancer	- Diabetes - Skin injury - Immunosuppression - Lymphedema
Location	Commonly affects calf or thigh (deep veins)	Affects skin and soft tissue, usually unilateral leg or arm
Pain Description	- Dull, aching, cramping pain - Worse with walking or standing	- Localized tenderness or burning sensation
Swelling	Unilateral leg swelling, pitting edema	Localized swelling, not usually pitting
Redness/Warmth	- Mild redness over vein path - Warm to touch	- Bright red, hot, and shiny skin
Skin Appearance	May look normal or slightly dusky	Shiny, tight, red, warm, possibly with blisters or drainage
Systemic Signs	- Possible low-grade fever - Risk of PE (dyspnea, chest pain)	- Fever, malaise, chills are common
Key Assessment Tests	- Homan's sign (pain on dorsiflexion — not reliable) - Duplex ultrasound	- Mark area with a pen to monitor progression
Labs/Imaging	- D-dimer (↑) - Venous Doppler ultrasound	- CBC (↑ WBCs) - Blood cultures (if febrile or severe)
Treatment	- Anticoagulation (e.g., Heparin, Warfarin)	

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	- Elevation, compression stockings (not in acute phase)	- Antibiotics (oral or IV) - Warm compresses - Pain control
Nursing Priorities	- Monitor for pulmonary embolism - Avoid massage - Encourage ambulation if stable	- Monitor spread of infection - Elevate limb - Educate on wound care
NCLEX Red Flag	Sudden shortness of breath or chest pain → Think PE	Rapidly spreading redness, high fever → Think sepsis risk

NCLEX TIPS FOR DVT VS. CELLULITIS:

◆ DVT KEY WORDS:

"Unilateral leg swelling," "pain with walking," "post-op," "immobile," "anticoagulants," "PE symptoms"

◆ CELLULITIS KEY WORDS:

"Red hot swollen skin," "localized," "bacterial infection," "antibiotics," "fever," "wound or insect bite"

DVT → PULMONARY EMBOLISM WARNING SIGNS (TEST FAVORITE!)

Sudden chest pain

Shortness of breath

Hemoptysis (coughing blood)

Decreased O2 saturation

➡ Immediate emergency! Call the provider and prepare for oxygen, imaging, and possible anticoagulation.